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THREE HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PROBLEMS IN THE ANCIENT SOURCES FOR THE REIGN OF CONSTANTIUS II (337-361)

Fordham University PH.D. 1982

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THREE HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PROBLEMS IN THE ANCIENT SOURCES FOR THE REIGN OF CONSTANTIUS II (337-361)

BY

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DISSERTATION
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This dissertation prepared under my direction by

Kelly Del Tredici

entitled "Three Historiographical Problems in the Ancient Sources for the Reign of Constantius II (337-61)"

has been accepted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the Degree of Doctor of Philosophy

M Pavelle

(Faculty Adviser)

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PREFACE

By way of introductory remarks, I chose to work in the reign of Constantius for the simple reason that it has been neglected to date by students of the Late Roman Empire, its obvious length (i.e., 337-361) notwithstanding. A glance through a card catalogue under the entries "Constantius II" and "Iulianus, Apostata" (361-363), for example, will serve to confirm this comparative dearth of modern scholarship devoted to Constantius and to the era of the sons of Constantine. My primary task, therefore, has been to keep the focus as much as possible on the emperor Constantius. Secondly, with the exception of his impact on the orthodox church as the empire's first Arian sovereign, which I have not discussed, the topics treated in each of the three chapters which follow emerged from my research as the major unresolved issues of Constantius' reign. Taken separately, they are independent entities, although the whole investigation in general may be said to be loosely unified by a common theme, namely, the problem of determining the imperial succession in a consistent, inviolable manner. In an attempt to strike a balance between the demand for thoroughness and the restrictions imposed on me by the need for selectivity I have limited myself to the literary evidence from the fourth to the sixth centuries, that is, to the authors beginning with Eusebius Pamphili and concluding with the last pagan historian of note from antiquity, Zosimus. Not included are numismatic or epigraphical source materials. Finally, wherever I have quoted a Greek writer at

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length in the body of the dissertation, I have supplied a corresponding English translation in appendix B, although the reader should be aware that I reserve the right to make whatever editorial changes I deemed necessary in order to bring the modern translation used into line with the edition of the given authority cited, either for stylistic purposes or for the sake of accuracy.

Personal thanks are due to the many who have taught me, but to none more than Professor Robert J. Penella, of Fordham University, for his patient and painstaking guidance.

I dedicate this work in gratitude to my parents and to the memory of my friend Margaret Longobardi.

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CHAPTER I

THE SUCCESSION CRISIS OF 337/38

It is only equitable to admit from the outset that the problems involved in a critical study of the succession crisis and massacre which marked the commencement of Constantius' imperial tenure may well be insoluble. In the works of ancient and modern authors alike the chronology, specifically the sequence of events from Constantine I's decease at Ancyrona, a suburb of Nicomedia, on 22 May 337 until September of that same year and shortly thereafter (early 338), is hopelessly incomplete; moreover, where such facts as have come down to us are certain their exact meaning is obscure.[1] The confusion, however, surrounding the events antecedent to, including, and immediately subsequent to the violent deaths of virtually the entire "branches collatérales de la maison

[1]See Henry Melvill Gwatkin, Studies of Arianism (Cambridge: Deighton, Bell, & Co., 1882), n. 4, pp. 108-9; Ernest Stein, Histoire du Bas-Empire, trans. by Jean-Remy Palanque, vol. 1: De l'État Romain à l'État Byzantin (284-476) (Paris: Desclée De Brouwer, 1959), pp. 131-32; Carlo Di Spigno, "Appunti per una lettura del libro XIV di Ammiano Marcellino," Orpheus 7(1960), especially pp. 133-34; Arnold Hugh Martin Jones, The Later Roman Empire, 284-602: A Social, Economic, and Administrative Survey, vol. 1 (Norman: University of Oklahoma Press, 1964), pp. 84-85, 112, 115; François Paschoud, ed., Zosime: Histoire Nouvelle, vol. 1, Collection Budé (Paris: Société d'Édition "Les Belles Lettres," 1971), n. 52, p. 245; André Piganiol, L'Empire Chrétien (325-395) (2nd ed.; Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1972), pp. 81-82; Diana Bowder, The Age of Constantine and Julian (London: Elek Books, 1978), p. 42; Joe W. Leedom, "Constantius II: Three Revisions," Byzantion 48(1978), 132-45.

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constantinienne en ligne masculine"[2] descended from Constantius Chlorus and his second royal consort Theodora, together with those of the patrician Optatus, Ablabius the recently retired praetorian prefect (329-337) of the Orient, and, according to Jerome's Chronicle A.D. 338 (p. 234 [Helm]), countless other high-placed persons from the former regime, i.e., multi nobilium occisi, extends back in time at least as far as the year 335.[3]

Today the general consensus of scholarly opinion is that perhaps prior to the summer of 335 Constantine, aged sixty-three, either out of foresight or because of failing health undertook arrangements for the partitioning of the Roman Empire among his heirs apparent, namely his three sons by Fausta: Constantine II (b. 2 February 317 and Caesar, with Crispus and Licinius since March of the same year), Constantius II (b. 8 August 317 or 318 and Caesar since 11 November 324), and Constans (b. 320

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[2]Stein-Palanque, p. 131. None escaped (or were spared) save Gallus, Julian, and Nepotianus. See Gwatkin, Studies, p. 108 and n. 2, ibid. See also Joseph Vogt, "Pagans and Christians in the Family of Constantine the Great," in The Conflict Between Paganism and Christianity in the Fourth Century, ed. by Arnaldo Momigliano (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1963), pp. 50-51; Paschoud, 1, n. 52, p. 246; Robert Browning, The Emperor Julian (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 1975), p. 31; and Glen Warren Bowersock, Julian the Apostate (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1978), p. 22.

[3]For the stemma of the Constantinian dynasty, see A.H.M. Jones, J.R. Martindale, and J. Morris, The Prosopography of the Later Roman Empire, vol. 1: A.D. 260-395 (Cambridge: University Press, 1971), p. 1129, photostatically reproduced in appendix A on p. 134. Optatus: the spouse of Constantine's sister (by Theodora) Anastasia (the widow of Bassianus), Fl. Optatus had been the first, along with Julius Constantius (see n. 6 below), to be granted the honorary title of patrician revived by Constantine I. According to PLRE, 1, p. 650, Optatus was formerly a schoolmaster who taught the son of Licinius. Ablabius: like Optatus, he was related to the house of Constantine by marriage, i.e., his daughter Olympias was affianced with the emperor's youngest son, Constans. See Vogt, pp. 50-51; PLRE, 1, pp. 3-4; and Piganiol, p. 81. Jerome: the word multi is disconcerting; does it mean six or sixty persons?

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or 323 and Caesar since 333). Latecomers, but likewise included in the "réorganisation territoriale de 335,"[4] were two of the emperor's nephews (sons, therefore, of his half-brother Fl. Dalmatius the Elder and cousins of Constantius): Dalmatius (or Delmatius) the Younger (elevated to the rank of Caesar on 9 September 335) and Hannibalianus the Younger (henceforth to be called Rex regum Ponticarum and nobilissimus).[5]

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[4] X. Lucien-Brun, "Constance II et le massacre des princes," BAGB 32 (1973), p. 586. See also Jules Bidez, La vie de l'Empereur Julien, Collection Budé (Paris: Société d'Édition "Les Belles Lettres," 1930), p. 12; J. Moreau, "Constantius I, Constantinus II, Constantius II, Constans," JbAC 2(1959), p. 179; R.C. Blockley, "Constantius Gallus and Julian as Caesars of Constantius II," Latomus 21(1972), p. 459; Piganiol, pp. 61 and 82; and Leedom, pp. 132-33. Constantine II and Constantius II: believed by Moreau, p. 164, and Paschoud, 1, n. 30, pp. 211-12, to have been the legitimate offspring of Constantine and Fausta, although Piganiol, n. 1, p. 82, and Browning, p. 39, think Constantine II was a bastard. See also PLRE, 1, p. 223. For the summer of 335 and the accession of Constantine's sons, together with Dalmatius, to the rank of Caesar, see Eusebius' Laus Constantini (also called Oratio de laudibus Constantini or τριακονταετηρικός), 3.1-4; according to H.A. Drake, In Praise of Constantine: A Historical Study and New Translation of Eusebius' Tricennial Orations, University of California Publications: Classical Studies, vol. 15 (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1976), pp. 43 and 45, the first ten chapters of the address can be dated to July of 336 at Constantinople. See also Aur. Victor Caes. 41.8-15 (Pichlmayr). Crispus: Constantine's eldest (and only) son by his first consort, Minervina, he was eliminated in the midst of a brilliant military career just prior to 18 July 326 at Pola, unexpectedly and at his father's orders, en route to the emperor's Vicennalia celebration at Rome. See Vogt, pp. 48-49; P. Guthrie, "The Execution of Crispus," Phoenix 20(1966), 325-31; PLRE, 1, p. 233; Paschoud, 1, n. 39, p. 221; and Blockley, "Gallus and Julian," p. 457 and n. 5, ibid.

[5] Rex regum et Ponticarum: see Anon. Val. 6.35. See also H.M. Gwatkin and J.P. Whitney, eds., The Cambridge Medieval History, vol. 1: The Christian Roman Empire and the Foundation of the Teutonic Kingdoms (Cambridge: University Press, 1957), p. 22. Constantine's half-brothers, Julius Constantius (the elder of the two, b. 292/93) and Dalmatius the Elder, were omitted from this settlement which was confined to the next generation. Julius Constantius had been recalled ca. 324 to court (where he married Julian's mother Basilina ca. 330), was appointed consul for the year 335, and, together with Fl. Optatus (see n. 4 above) was granted the honorary title of patrician. Similarly, Dalmatius the Elder was made consul in 335 and received, around the same time, the rank and title of censor prior to being placed in charge of the investigation, in 336, of the

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Scholars are not nearly so unanimous, however, in their views regarding the actual nature and geographical extent of each of the four Caesars' jurisdiction. The issue is complicated further by historians' very imperfect knowledge of the exact number and composition of the prefectures and dioceses into which the Roman Empire had been sub-divided under Diocletian for administrative purposes, and whose names and boundaries were subject to periodic shifts until the final division of the empire in 395.[6] As far as I am able to determine, it was Constantine's intention in 335 that two of his four Caesars designate govern four dioceses apiece, and one of them three: Constantine II the two Gauls, Spain, and Britain; Constans the dioceses comprising both Italies, Africa, and Pannonia; and Dalmatius Dacia and Macedonia (i.e., Moesia, including what

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case against Athanasius, bishop of Alexandria from 328-373. See W. Enslin, "Dalmatius Censor," RhM 78(1929), 205 ff. From 334/35 he held a military command in the East, where he suppressed the usurper Calocaerus in Cyprus. Although assigned smaller shares than Constantine's sons, whom the project of 335 clearly favored, it is clear that the younger Dalmatius, certainly, and Hannibalianus, recently crowned king of Armenia, were earmarked by their uncle the emperor to participate in the succession. See Ausonius, Prof. 17.9-10 (illic [i.e., Narbo] Dalmatio genitos, fatalia regum/nomina, tum pueros [Pretel]). Finally, the entire arrangement was cemented by dynastic marriages, i.e., the daughter of Julius Constantius by a previous union wed Constantius II in 335, while the younger Hannibalianus espoused Constantine's daughter by Fausta, Constantina (also mistakenly called Constantia and Constantiniana). See PLRE, 1, pp. 240-41 and 407. See also Bidez, pp. 7 and 12; Moreau, p. 164; Stein-Palanque, p. 131; Vogt, pp. 50-51; Paschoud, 1, n. 52, pp. 245-46; Piganiol, pp. 60-61 and 82; and Bowder, p. 43.

[6]Geographical distribution: see Georg Wissowa, ed., Pauly's Real-Encyclopädie der classischen Altertumswissenschaft, vol. 4 (Stuttgart: J.B. Metzlerscher Verlag, 1901), 1046; hereafter referred to simply as PW; Moreau, p. 179; Stein-Palanque, pp. 131-32; LRE, 1, pp. 85 and 112; Paschoud, 1, n. 54, p. 247; Piganiol, p. 61 and n. 3, p. 83; Leedom, n. 7, p. 133; and Bowder, p. 43. See also Stein-Palanque, "L'Empire romain en 309" (map) photostatically reproduced in appendix A on p. 135. Dioceses and prefectures: see Stein-Palanque, p. 132, J.M. Hussey, The Byzantine World (New York: Harper & Row, Publishers, 1961), p. 13; and LRE, 1, pp. 370 and 373. See also n. 9 below.

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is often loosely termed the ripa Gothica), as well as Thrace. Constantius, by contrast, was to exercise sovereignty over only two dioceses, the Orient and Asia, but these constituted the wealthiest and most desirable pieces of real estate, which Constantine "formerly had thought best reserved for himself." (See Julian, Or. 3.94a-b [Bidez, 11]).[7] To Hannibalianus fell the diocese of Pontus, the smallest of the four shares to be sure, but doubtless with the greatest potential for expansion if ever a Romanized Persian Empire should become a reality.[8] Three further points can be clarified at this juncture: first, the breakdown described here does not correspond to the four (or even three) imperial prefectures enumerated in the Notitia Dignitatum; next, it seems that Constans (who would have been only twelve or fifteen years old in 335) together with his dominions were entrusted to the direction of Constantine II until the former should come of age; finally, under the present arrangement neither Rome nor Constantinople fell to the eldest or elder two brothers. That is, although Constantius was to rule the East, its capital city was located in the diocese of Thrace and so belonged to Dalmatius Caesar under whose jurisdiction Thrace had been placed. Similarly, while Constantine II controlled eight dioceses in the West by virtue of a certain primacy

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[7]Moesia: it seems that Constantine partitioned Diocletian's diocese of Moesia into a Dacian and Macedonian diocese respectively at some time prior to 327. See Stein-Palanque, n. 1, p. 484 and Piganiol, p. 13. Ripa Gothica: probably signifying the region of the lower Danube, see Bidez, p. 12; LRE, 1, pp. 85 and 99. Pannonia: also called Illyricum, see Stein-Palanque, p. 230 and also N.G.L. Hammond and H.H. Scullard, eds., Oxford Classical Dictionary (2nd ed.; Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1970), p. 541.

[8]Pontus: some scholars assign this diocese to Constantius, but this is untenable if one recalls that Hannibalianus had received the title of Rex regum et Ponticarum. Romanized Persian Empire: see Bidez, p. 12 and especially CMH, 1, pp. 22-23. See also PW 4(1901), 1046.

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over his younger brother, it was Constans, in theory, who eventually was to govern Italy and with it the capital city of Rome.[9]

Having provided for the succession, Constantine attempted to anticipate potential contingencies. In 336, for instance, he reduced to slave status by law (Cod. Th. IV.6.2, dated 29 April and IV.6.3, dated 21 July [Meyer and Mommsen]) and executed by year's end the illegitimate son of his former co-Augustus Licinius, one Licinianus, whom the emperor had spared in 324 subsequent to Licinius' defeat at Adrianople and Chrysopolis.[10] Constantine I must have died in the happy expectation that all would function smoothly after he had gone to his eternal reward. Sed dis aliter visum--which brings us back to the year 337 and the death of the emperor near Nicomedia.

The ancient sources provide little detailed information for the interim period following Constantine's decease, but on the basis of the

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[9]Notitia Dignitatum: dated by LRE, 2, p. 1451 to ca. 408, with later revisions down to the year 423 in the West. See also ibid., p. 1417f. According to the Notitia, Thrace belonged to the prefecture of the East, whereas in 335 it was linked with the dioceses of Dacia and Macedonia which, normally, taken with Pannonia, Italy, and Africa, comprised the prefecture of Illyricum (also called the prefecture of Italy). See CMH, 1, p. 22 and Stein-Palanque, p. 132. Leedom's analysis (p. 133) of the prefectural breakdown is faulty. Subordinate role of Constans: only Paschoud, 1, n. 52, p. 245 and n. 53, p. 247, writes as if Constantine II's guardianship over Constans existed from the very start. I find it difficult to believe that such a relationship was instituted only subsequent to the massacre and a new re-apportionment of the empire among the survivors. But see PW 4(1901), 1047; CMH, 1, p. 56; Moreau, p. 179; and Piganiol, p. 83. Constantinople and Rome: see Gwatkin, Studies, p. 108 and Leedom, p. 132. Were all or only some of the Caesars to become Augusti following Constantine's death? See Stein-Palanque, p. 131.

[10]See The Theodosian Code and Novels and the Sirmondian Constitutions, trans., by Clyde Pharr (New York: Greenwood Press, Publishers, 1961), p. 86. See also PW 13.1(1926), 231 and Piganiol, p. 61. So much for Lucien-Brun's theory (p. 586) that Constantine planned the succession in a haphazard manner!

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facts that we do possess most modern historians agree on the following hypothetical sequence of events:[11] (1) from Constantine's death on 22 May 337 approximately a three-month interregnum (see Cod. Th. XIII.4.2 [Meyer and Mommsen] issued on 2 August 337 in the deceased's name) during which a purge took place at Constantinople. Among its victims were the elder and younger Dalmatius, Hannibalianus the Younger, Julius Constantius, a nameless older brother of the future emperor Julian, together with Optatus and Ablabius; (2) Constantine II, Constantius, and Constans declare themselves Augusti on 9 September 337 (this date based on the testimony of Idatius) at an unspecified location, and are recognized as such by the Roman Senate; (3) on 12 June 338 (utilizing Cod. Th. X.10.4 [Meyer and Mommsen], addressed by Constantius [or possibly Constantine II] to the praetorian prefect Celsinus), the three brothers meet at Viminacium in Pannonia to re-partition the empire--Constantine II almost certainly is to exercise tutelage over Constans (to whom had been awarded almost the whole of the younger Dalmatius' former portion), and so in fact controls ten out of the fourteen dioceses.[12]

The preceding schema represents the majority opinion regarding the succession crisis controversy, but four additional schemata have been advanced as follows: first, (1) from 22 May 337 an interregnum in the course of which a massacre occurred at Constantinople; (2) a new division

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[11]See Gwatkin, Studies, p. 108 and n. 4, pp. 108-9; PW 4(1901), 1046-47; CMH, p. 55; Moreau, p. 164; Stein-Palanque, pp. 131-32; and LRE, 1, pp. 112-13.

[12]Fourteen dioceses: see pp. 4-5 above. Interregnum and Cod. Th. XIII.4.2: see Bidez, p. 4 and n. 9, p. 359. See also Stein-Palanque, "L'Empire romain en 309" (map) photostatically reproduced in appendix A on p. 136. Constantius settled for the diocese of Thrace and Hannibalianus' kingdom. See Gwatkin, Studies, p. 108; PW 4(1901), 1047; CMH, 1, Stein-Palanque, p. 132 and n. 6, p. 485; Paschoud, 1, n. 52, p. 245 and n. 53, p. 246; Piganiol, p. 83; and Bowder, p. 44.

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of the empire at Viminacium (not, however, identical with that of 12 June 338 above); (3) on 9 September 337 the three sons of Constantine declare themselves Augusti at an unspecified location and are recognized by the Senate of Rome.[13] Secondly, (1) from 22 May 337 an interregnum; (2) Constantine II, Constantius, and Constans declare themselves Augusti on 9 September 337 (perhaps at Viminacium) and are recognized by the Roman Senate; (3) the massacre at Constantinople--there is no mention of a re-division of the empire unless the reader is to assume that it took place on 9 September 337 at Viminacium in (2) here.[14] Thirdly, (1) from 22 May 337 an interregnum; (2) on 9 Semptember 337 the three brothers are declared Augusti at an unspecified location, followed by (3) the purge at Constantinople and (4) a re-partitioning of the dioceses at Sirmium in Pannonia on 27 September 338 (this date based on Cod. Th. XV.1.5 [Meyer and Mommsen], addressed by Constantius and Constans to one Catullinus. Finally, (1) from 22 May 337 an interregnum in the midst of which the brothers re-divided the empire among themselves in conference at Viminacium (once again, not to be confused with that of 12 June 338, but possibly occurring around the same time as Athanasius' visit with Constantius on

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[13] See Paschoud, 1, nn. 52-53, pp. 245-246.

[14] See Bidez, pp. 14-15 and n. 9, p. 359, and Giuseppe Ricciotti, Julian the Apostate, trans. from the original L'imperatore Giuliano l' Apostata (2nd ed.; 1958) by M. Joseph Costelloe (Milwaukee: Bruce Publishing Co., 1960), p. 7. Only Bowder, pp. 43-44, explicitly makes the connection between 9 September 337 and the congress at Viminacium as perhaps intend Henric Nordberg, Athanasius and the Emperor, Societas Scientiarum Fennica, Commentationes Humanarum Litterarum, vol. 30 (Helsinki: Helsingfors, 1963), pp. 33-34; Piganiol, pp. 82-83; Browning, pp. 34-35; and Leedom, pp. 133-35.

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his way back to Alexandria where he arrived from exile on 23 November 337);[15] (2) the brothers' declaration at an unspecified location as Augusti on 9 September 337, followed by their recognition by the Roman Senate; and (3) the massacre at Constantinople.[16]

Upon closer analysis, all of the reconstructions above present a serious difficulty. In particular, a careful reading of the ancient sources reveals that not a single one explicity situates the extermination of Julius Constantius, Julian's unnamed older brother, Dalmatius the Elder together with his two sons, or Optatus at Constantinople. In fact, of all the victims it seems that only Julius Constantius and his family were living there at the time and had been permanent residents of the city since 330.[17] Perhaps the assassins' orders merely originated

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[15]See Athan. Apol. Const. 601b (Szymusiak) and the Chronicon praevium 6b (PG 26, 1353). See also Archibald Robertson, ed., Select Writings and Letters of Athanasius, Bishop of Alexandria, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers of the Christian Church, Second Series, vol. 4 (Grand Rapids, Michigan: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co., 1953), n. 13, p. 503 and Nordberg, p. 33. See also Theod. HE 2.4 (Parmentier). On the date of Athanasius' return from exile, see Gwatkin, Studies, pp. 108-9 and Robertson, NPFC, 4, pp. 495-96.

[16]See Piganiol, pp. 82-83, especially n. 4, p. 82. Piganiol's application of the evidence from Athanasius does not prove the major point that he wishes to stress here, namely, that the massacre necessarily took place subsequent to 9 September 337; rather, it would seem to me to indicate only that the meeting at Viminacium occurred prior to 23 November 337 and not on 12 June 338 as the authors cited in n. 11 above have suggested who identify this same meeting of the three brothers in Pannonia with the conference alluded to in Cod. Th. X.10.4. As Piganiol's argument stands, his asseveration that the massacre must have occurred after 9 September 337 sometime is groundless unless it can be determined that the purge came about (as Piganiol, p. 83, goes on to suggest) in anticipation of an equally violent reaction by the younger Dalmatius, Hannibalianus, and their partisans to their exclusion from the succession arranged by Constantine in 335.

[17]See Bidez, p. 8. Moreau, p. 164, believes that Hannibalianus, who lived in Cappadocia, died at Caesarea, but he cites no ancient authority to substantiate his claim. See also Piganiol, p. 63.

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at the capital; such was the case with Ablabius, who Eunapius of Sardis (V. Soph. 6.3.13 [Giangrande]) gloatingly recounts for us was "hacked to pieces like some animal cut up at a public feast"[18] on his retirement estate in Bithynia. On the other hand, definitive proof that the massacre did come to pass at Constantinople might provide scholars with the evidence they require to pinpoint the date of the violence more accurately. The solemn inauguration of Constantine's New Rome on 11 May 330 notwithstanding, we know today that the imperial family and court did not reside there continuously or permanently until the reign of Theodosius I (379-395).[19] Presumably, the only occasion on which all six known victims would have appeared on the scene simultaneously at Constantinople would have been for the duration of the mourning period following the emperor's decease, which included the disposition of his last will and testament, his lying-in-state, funeral, and interment (Eus. V. Const. 4.64-70 [Heikel, 11]).[20] On the assumption that this may have been the case, we can situate the massacre of the relatives within the time frame of the three-month interregnum, i.e., soon after 22 May 337 but prior to the date 9 September 337.

A further problem is posed by the second and fifth schemata which fail to specify precise dates for the congress in Pannonia: this being the case, one wonders whether the correct sequence of events should

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[18]Wilmer Cave Wright, ed., Philostratus and Eunapius: The Lives of the Sophists, The Loeb Classical Library (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1952).

[19]Imperial residence at Constantinople: see LRE, 1, p. 366 and Gilbert Dagron, Naissance d'une capitale: Constantinople et ses institutions de 330 à 451 (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1974), p. 86 and see also pp. 79-85.

[20]But cf. Philostorgius' Ecclesiastical History 2.16 (Bidez) and p. 19 ff. below.

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entail Viminacium (or Sirmium) followed by the proclamation as Augusti on 9 September 337, or vice versa. Moreover, even where supposedly firm dates for the meeting (or meetings?) of the three brothers in Pannonia have been supplied with the aid of the Codex Theodosianus, e.g., 12 June 338 and 27 September 338, how can we be certain that these dates will align with the events presently in question?

Finally, there is the "indispensable but aggravating"[21] testimony of Jerome (Chronicle A.D. 338 [p. 234] Helm), who informs us that Ablabius, many members of the nobility, and Dalmatius Caesar were slain in 338. These data not only argue against the thesis I have just proposed above (p. 10), but against those of all five schemata as well--unless, of course, there was more than one spate of killings.[22] Admittedly, the most appealing solution would be one that takes into account, at the very least, the three major objections I have raised here (pp. 9-11).

More important than a resolution of the chronology problem, however, and an alternate means of untangling the conflicting sequences of events is an examination of the ancient texts to determine whom the writers hold responsible for the murders, their alleged motivation, and their actual consequences. The oldest version is the one which dates back to the

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[21]Ernest Cushing Richardson, ed., NPFC, 1 (1952), p. 447.

[22]This last does not seem at all improbable in my estimation; see n. 3 above. The so-called "massacre" may not have been an altogether one-time "fell-swoop" operation. Instead, it initially may have involved the emperor's half-brothers and nephew, and then gradually have spread to engulf the likes of Ablabius, Optatus, and the multi nobilium (although the first two individuals, clearly, were related to the house of Constantine by marriage). See also the tantalizing scrap of information volunteered by Athan. Chronicon praevium 6c (PG 26, 1353) for the year 338/39, although the reference may be to ecclesiastical affairs: Hoc anno multis concitatis tumultis.

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emperor Constantine's contemporary and confidant, Eusebius Pamphili, bishop of Caesarea from 313 until his death ca. 340.[23] Published between the emperor's death and the year 340, his Vita Constantini (especially 4.63-70 [Heikel, 1]) represents the earliest source in Greek or Latin to claim that a zealous military, upon hearing the news of Constantine's decease, took matters into its own hands:

> καὶ οἵδε μὲν τάδ' ἔπραττον, ὅσπερ δὲ ἐξ ἐπιπνοίας κρείττονος τὰ πανταχοῦ πάντα στρατόπεδα τὸν βασιλέως πυθόμενα θάνατον μιᾶς ἐκράτει γνώμης, ὡσανεὶ ζῶντος αὐτοῖς τοῦ μεγάλου βασιλέως μηδένα γνωρίζειν ἕτερον ἢ μόνους τοὺς αὐτοῦ παῖδας Ῥωμαίων αὐτοκράτορας. οὐκ εἰς μακρὸν δ' ἠξίουν μὴ καίσαρας ἐντεῦθεν δ' ἤδη τοὺς ἅπαντας χρηματίζειν αὐγούστους, ὃ δὴ πρώτιστον καὶ μέγιστον τῆς ἀνωτάτω βασιλείας γίγνοιτ' ἂν σύμβολον. οἱ μὲν οὖν ταῦτ' ἔπραττον, τὰς οἰκείας ψήφους τε καὶ φωνὰς διὰ γραφῆς ἀλλήλοις διαγγέλλοντες, ὑπὸ μίαν τε καιροῦ ῥοπὴν τοῖς ἁπανταχοῦ πᾶσιν ἐγνωρίζετο ἡ τῶν στρατοπέδων συμφωνία. (4.68.1-10 [Heikel, 1])

In V. Const. 4.69.21-23, Eusebius relates how the senate and people of Rome "declared his [i.e., Constantine's] sons alone to be emperors and Augusti," adding at 4.70, "the second of his sons, . . . who had by this time arrived, proceeded to celebrate his father's funeral in the city which bears his name, himself heading the procession."[24] The V. Const. piously concludes, never mentioning a word about the younger Dalmatius, Hannibalianus, or dynastic bloodshed at Constantinople. As far as Eusebius is concerned, then, the army was the driving force behind the proclamation of the new Augusti, Constantius was at Constantinople for the emperor's funeral which he conducted alone (where were brothers Constantine II and Constans?), and finally, there was no massacre. Eusebius' silence on

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[23] See Hans Von Campenhausen, The Fathers of the Greek Church, trans. from the original Griechische Kirchenväter (1955) by Stanley Godman (New York: Pantheon Books, 1959), p. 63.

[24] See Richardson, NPFC, 1 (1952).

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this last point is galling. One is forced to conclude either that no violence occurred (or at least not immediately after Constantine's death), or else that Eusebius was ignorant of the assassinations of his former sovereign's nephews (which is unlikely), or that his failure to advert to the murders was intentional. Given the bishop's proximity in time and place in 337/38 to the events and persons at court, this omission on his part presumably is wilful.[25]

Another fourth century source to mention the army in connection with Constantine's passing and, this time, the succession crisis as well is Aurelius Victor, whose Liber de Caesaribus perhaps was published ca. 361, the same year in which the emperor Julian promoted him to the governorship of Pannonia Secunda (see Amm. 21.10.6 [Seyfarth, 13). Writing approximately twenty years after Eusebius, Victor recalls (at 41.15) how in 335 Constantine elevated Dalmatius the Younger to the rank of Caesar, i.e., Caesarem iussit obsistentibus valide militaribus (Pichlmayr) -- "despite bitter resistance on the part of the soldiery." After relating the circumstances surrounding Constantine's death and funeral at Constantinople (41.16-17), Victor resumes: Igitur confestim Dalmatius, incertum quo suasore [Constantius?], interficitur" (41.22). It is tempting to credit the army with Dalmatius' undoing after Constantine's death on 22 May 337 since earlier it had exerted negative pressure on the emperor in his nephews' regard even during his lifetime, but Victor does not go that far. Still, his Liber de Caesaribus does not overlook the historical

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[25] In a similar vein, Eusebius neglected to report in his V. Const. the execution of Constantine's eldest son, Crispus.

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